

Escape Room Reflection

Cole Sanders

The escape room project was based on a continuation of the dungeon crawler. After Dimitri completes the dungeon crawler he has to escape from the clinic he's trapped in. I worked on item creation, puzzle implementation, inventory system, item interaction, puzzle interaction, and prop interaction.

It was a fun project. The whole idea behind our escape room was to find objects scattered about or inside props such as drawers or cabinets and use them to progress. Progression was blocked by doors that required certain conditions to be met. This was done with requiring the user to input certain items into the blocker in certain orders. There were also hints created and scattered throughout the map to help the player in their escape. I think more work could be done on connecting the puzzles to the narrative. They make sense in the context of the story but upon review I think it would have been a nice touch if the puzzles had a deeper meaning. For example, connecting the items and their use to deeper narrative patterns that we had set up. Like connecting it back to Dimitri's origin story and him working through his past issues of stagnation in life. I think the metamorphosis was well done however. As the user progresses through the escape room, the map itself evolves. This was a well done concept that also adds the absurdism element into the game. The music was another well done element that contributes to the absurdism. It really adds an eerie aspect with a series of discordant chords being played on repeat.

The pacing of our work could use improvement. Unfortunately only half our team made consistent progress on the game throughout the development timeframe. As a result, a lot of the features were not fully implemented. Our plan of having scrum updates every other day did not

fix our issue of inconsistent development effort. Some of the items I created did not make it into the game because the puzzle infrastructure was not developed in accordance with the design. I will say the design and planning went much better than with the dungeon crawler. The design document was much more clear and there wasn't as much left out. However, some of our team really struggled with the implementation portion. The narrative element additionally was thrown on very late in the process and that made it difficult to tie everything together. I feel like this made the game less cohesive than it should have been. Additionally, because of the late implementation the puzzle variety was a bit lacking. The only puzzle type that ended up in the final game was the one I implemented with dragging and dropping items from the user inventory into puzzle slots in the correct order. We had a cool puzzle design where there should have been two more puzzle types. However due to the delay in the implementation, they didn't make it into the final product.

I think time management and implementation were by far the biggest factors holding back the team's development cycle. Many great elements were there, but the design wasn't able to be fully implemented and there wasn't enough time to test for cohesiveness and fine tune for playability. I think in future we need stricter deadlines and to make sure those deadlines are followed religiously. I think our ideas had a lot of potential.

Another aspect for improvement is communication within the team. Deadlines weren't met but no explanation was given. Changes were made to the original design but what changed was not clearly communicated. I think everyone being on the same page would help the development process and people could work to make their individually implemented components more cohesive with the overall game.

My favorite part was creating the interactable parts. Creating items that you could pick up, making it so you can inspect different props and that automatically pulls items into your inventory, and working on the drag and drop puzzle interface. I like working on the interactive elements because you can see all the work you put into the game come alive. I also like adding hints, such as the red or green feedback when the player tries the wrong or correct object respectively. Or adding item scrolls throughout the game with hints on how to order certain items in certain puzzles. With puzzle games, I think there is a fine line between way too easy and way too tedious. Trying to find that balance was hard. One of the idea's I played around with was adding hints directly on the puzzle to guide the user. However this may have made it trivially easy to complete the game. On the other hand, if the user does not manage to find the hint objects scattered around, it could make the game very tedious as the user just randomly tries to fit different objects into different slots. Another mechanic I would like to have introduced is either a time limit or a limited number of guesses for each puzzle. I feel like for me personally, these types of difficulty mechanics make the game more enjoyable and rewarding. Perhaps it could have been added as an optional "medium" and "hard" mode.

Overall I think this game made some improvements on the issues faced in the dungeon crawler game. The planning stage was through, there were not large aspects of the games left out and not assigned to anyone. Everyone knew what they were supposed to do and timelines were set to complete these tasks. Unfortunately, the main struggle with this game was with the implementation portion. Some teammates only implemented right before the beta and final due dates. That makes it difficult to work with dependencies where one thing cannot be added until another thing is already in the game. It also makes it difficult to polish the final product because

there is simply no time. I feel like the potential was there, the ideas were great, but the implementation really held back the delivery.